

FREE BONUS

Checklist Pack
First Meat Canning Session

Follow these step by step and avoid the most common beginner mistakes

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WHAT'S INSIDE THIS PACK

✓ **CHECKLIST 1 — Equipment List**
Everything you need before your first session — and what to check before every season.

✓ **CHECKLIST 2 — Step-by-Step Canning Process**
From the night before to the 24-hour seal check — every step in order.

Both checklists are printable. Keep them in the kitchen while you work.

CHECKLIST 1

Equipment List

Check before every canning session. Replace anything that fails inspection.

A. EQUIPMENT INVENTORY — DO YOU HAVE EVERYTHING?

- ☐ Pressure Canner
- ☐ Jars
- ☐ Flat lids — NEW every session (single use only)
- ☐ Screw bands/rings (reusable if not rusted or bent)
- ☐ Jar lifter
- ☐ Canning funnel
- ☐ Bubble remover
- ☐ Headspace tool
- ☐ Kitchen timer (or phone)
- ☐ Permanent marker + labels
- ☐ Clean damp cloths or paper towels for rim wiping

Optional but useful

- ☐ Lid wand / magnetic lid lifter

⚠️ **Never use commercial jars (pasta sauce, mayonnaise) for pressure canning. Mason-type jars only.**

B. CANNER SAFETY CHECK — DO THIS BEFORE EVERY SEASON

All canners:

- ☐ Vent port is clear and unobstructed (hold up to light and look through)
- ☐ Gasket inspected — no cracks, dryness, or deformation
- ☐ Safety fuse or overpressure plug is intact and undamaged
- ☐ Canner rack is in place and undamaged

Dial-gauge canners only:

- ☐ Gauge tested for accuracy this season

💡 **Pro tip**

These checks take 10 minutes. Do them once per season — before your first session.
A canner that fails any of these checks should not be used until repaired.

CHECKLIST 2

Step-by-Step Canning Process

Follow in order. Do not skip steps. Keep this open on the counter while you work.

THE NIGHT BEFORE

- ☐ Soak beans if any recipe calls for them
- ☐ Thaw frozen meat in the refrigerator
- ☐ Check jar inventory — wash, inspect rims, set aside enough for the batch
- ☐ Prepare and measure all seasonings — label small containers if doing multiple recipes
- ☐ Check you have enough canning salt, new lids, and fresh broth or water

THE MORNING OF — BEFORE YOU START

- ☐ Set up workspace — clear and clean counter next to stove
- ☐ Set out all tools: jar lifter, funnel, bubble remover, headspace tool, timer
- ☐ Place rack inside canner and add 2–3 inches of hot water
- ☐ Wash jars and inspect rims — discard any with chips or cracks
- ☐ Keep jars hot until ready to fill

STEP 1 — Prepare Your Meat

- ☐ Trim visible fat to under ¼ inch
- ☐ Hot pack: pre-cook meat until rare — not fully done
- ☐ Raw pack: cut to size specified in recipe — keep refrigerated
- ☐ Bring canning liquid to a boil
- ☐ Measure all seasonings before filling

STEP 2 — Fill the Jars

- ☐ Work one jar at a time
- ☐ Place canning funnel in jar opening
- ☐ Pack meat loosely — do not force down
- ☐ Add hot liquid to cover (hot pack) or leave dry (raw pack)
- ☐ Add salt and seasonings as specified in recipe
- ☐ Run bubble remover around inside of jar
- ☐ Check headspace: 1 inch for most meats / 1¼ inch for chicken and rabbit
- ☐ Wipe jar rim with clean damp cloth — non-negotiable

- ☐ Place lid centered on rim, gasket side down
- ☐ Apply band fingertip-tight — firm but not forced

✓ **LAST CHECK BEFORE LOADING THE CANNER**

- ☐ Correct headspace on every jar
- ☐ No air bubbles visible
- ☐ Jar rim clean and dry
- ☐ Lid centered and band fingertip-tight
- ☐ All jars upright and ready

STEP 3 — Load the Canner and Vent

- ☐ Place jars on rack using jar lifter — keep upright at all times
- ☐ Lock canner lid securely
- ☐ Leave vent port open — do not add weight yet
- ☐ Heat on high until steady, continuous steam flows from vent port
- ☐ Start timer: vent for 10 full minutes — do not skip or shorten

STEP 4 — Pressurize and Process

- ☐ After 10 minutes venting: place weighted gauge or close petcock
- ☐ Wait for canner to reach correct pressure (3–10 minutes):
  - *Dial-gauge: watch needle reach correct PSI on the gauge*
  - *Weighted-gauge: weight begins to rock or jiggle steadily*
- ☐ Start processing timer when correct pressure is reached
- ☐ Adjust heat to maintain steady pressure throughout:
  - *Dial-gauge: keep needle at correct PSI — avoid large swings*
  - *Weighted-gauge: weight should rock gently — not violently*
- ☐ Confirm time and pressure in Appendix A for your canner type and altitude

⚠️ **If pressure drops at any point: bring back to pressure and restart timer from zero. Partial processing is not safe processing.**

STEP 5 — Depressurize and Remove Jars

- ☐ Turn off heat when processing time is complete
- ☐ Do NOT force-cool — no cold water, no fan, no early venting
- ☐ Let canner depressurize naturally: ~30 min for pints / ~45 min for quarts

- ☐ Confirm full depressurization:
  - *Dial-gauge: needle reads zero*
  - *Weighted-gauge: vent lock drops*
- ☐ Remove weighted gauge or open petcock
- ☐ Wait additional 10 minutes
- ☐ Open lid tilting away from you
- ☐ Remove jars with jar lifter — keep upright, do not tilt
- ☐ Place on towel or rack with 1 inch space between jars
- ☐ Do not retighten bands, press lids, or move jars
- ☐ Let cool undisturbed 12–24 hours

STEP 6 — The 24-Hour Seal Check

- ☐ Remove screw bands
- ☐ Press test: lid does not flex when pressed (concave = sealed)
- ☐ Tap test: clear high-pitched ring (dull sound = not sealed)
- ☐ Visual test: lid curves slightly downward at center

✅ **If sealed:**

- ☐ Wash outside of jar
- ☐ Label and store

❌ **If not sealed:**

- ☐ Refrigerate and use within several days
- ☐ OR reprocess within 24 hours with a new lid

🏷️ LABEL EVERY JAR BEFORE STORING

- ☐ Contents — be specific: "Beef Stew" not "Beef"
- ☐ Date canned — month and year
- ☐ Altitude processed — if above 1,000 ft (300 m)

All processing times and pressures sourced from the USDA Complete Guide to Home Canning, Guide 5. nchfp.uga.edu